

Assisted living

I bet many of you want a smartwatch. What about a VR display? If you can afford it, you probably already have a smart TV, and will soon have a smart fridge, then an AC, a cooker, washing machine, dishwasher and, eventually, a smart home. Obviously, a smart office as well, and a smart car that drives you around, because, well, by then there'll be traffic jams everywhere and we don't want to be frustrated dealing with that now, do we?

You're going to want, nay, need, help with doing just about everything. "It's evolution. The human brain needs to be able to focus on more complex things – do more thinking and waste less time on the mundane," you say.

From the time you wake up till the time you sleep, technology already assists you with everything (or will do so in the very near future). Let's take as simple an aspect of life as waking up on time, for starters.

I wake up thanks to an alarm I set on my phone. Actually, I don't. I always snooze, and even dismiss the alarm, and go right back to sleep. My phone however has four alarms, and is persistent, but only because I set it to be. How much longer before this becomes a truly smart phone and does this for me automatically? Maybe when setting my alarm it will ask me for the urgency, or what it is I want to wake up for. Maybe some day, it will be able to tell the difference between, "Wake me up at 5 a.m. I want to try and get some exercise", and "Wake me up at 5 a.m. I have a flight to catch". Obviously, one of these is way more important than the other, and the persistence levels of the alarm should vary based on that information.

The internet of things will ensure everything is connected eventually, and companies such as Google are already working on frameworks on which such devices could run. By the time you read this column, it should have announced Brillo – its Android-based OS that can run on very low-specced devices (as low as 32 MB of RAM). Obviously, Brillo will talk to your Android phone and allow you access to information about your fridge from anywhere, among other things. Just a litre of milk in the fridge? Up pops a notification on your phone... you get the idea. We've covered the internet of things ourselves several times before – check out our PDF archives in the DVDs.

However, for me, the internet of things and smartphones and touch devices are all still just

stepping stones to the eventual goal: a truly invisible UI.

A voice in your head, perhaps. Cortana and Siri and the likes, but smarter, and just for you. A display that pops up only when you need it, or appears to, but is actually just electrical signals sent to your brain, or eyes. Also, it has to be a personalised experience. My wife's way of using technology is very different from mine, so why should we have the same interface, screens and layout?

Not too many of us in India talk to our phones, because, well, it's daft. Apart from our surroundings being too crowded and noisy, digital assistants make mistakes (although most are getting better at recognising our accents). That aside, the stares you'd get would make you shut up any way.

Now, think about an in-ear phone that your assistant talks to you through (yes, like the movie *Her*), and that you don't need to physically talk back to, but can just move your lips subtly and some wearable camera somewhere will lip read and send that information to your assistant. This isn't science fiction, most of it's being worked on already.

I spent a few months looking at assisted living homes for my dad, and the facilities they offer are scarily similar to the ones technology is beginning to offer us.

He can't take care of himself because of a physical disability, and thus he needs help to move, serve him food, book a cab to travel, buy everyday things such as groceries... basically, he needs human help to be able to function as a normal human.

This is not too different from how I am today. My disability is mental, however, and I can't function without technology to assist me. We will all eventually need it to help us wake, eat, do our daily chores, keep us entertained, appropriately medicated, healthy, prolong our lives, help us sleep...

Is technology just turning us into senior citizens a lot faster? And is that really an evolution in the positive direction? I guess time will tell... 



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